

agrees the work has stopped for almost two years now and security screening machines are languishing—but adds that he referred what is essentially a conservation matter to the Supreme Court because it is “monitoring all activity around the Taj Mahal”.

ASI spends almost Rs 50 lakh a year on the maintenance and conservation of the Taj Mahal, the most viewed monument in India, with almost 10,000 visitors every day. The aim of TMCC was to create welcoming entrances, beautify the garden and upgrade the water sys-

tem. The six-year-long project, says Batliwala, has “seen a lot of back and forth, with several changes of DGs at ASI as well as member-secretaries of NCI”. During its patience-testing course, NCI consulted some of the best conservationists in India and abroad on the historical accuracy of the plans. One of the experts, art historian Ebba Koch, traced the visitors’ centres idea to *khawasspuras* (servants’ quarters), which were conceived as residential quarters for the sentries of Mumtaz Mahal’s mausoleum. As Koch writes in

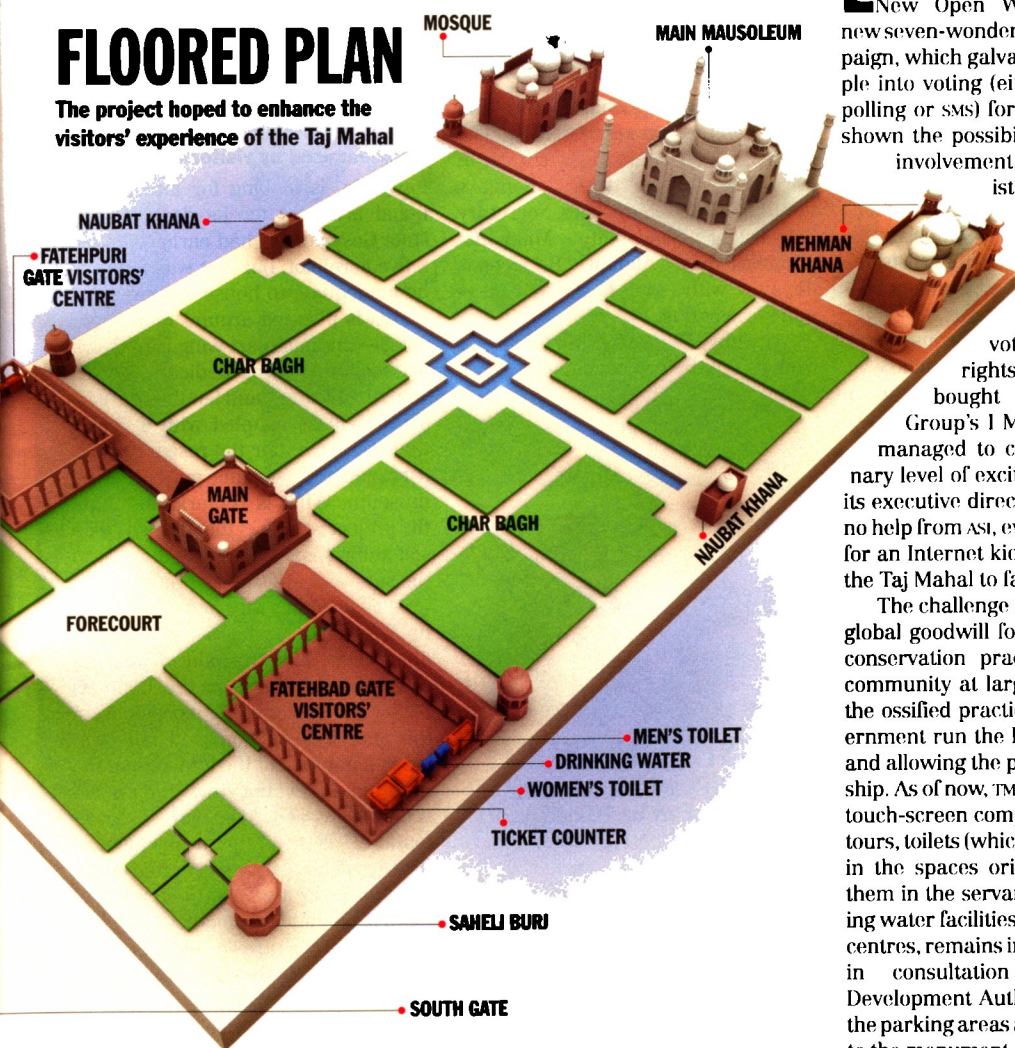
her report submitted to the ASI, the courtyards had no religious significance, which led to their gradual disuse and then ruin. The TMCC project hoped not only to revive the quarters but also provide for a comprehensive visitor management plan—based on a survey undertaken by TMCC, which showed, among other problems, the glaring absence of a site map, poor standard of toilets and inappropriately placed drinking water counters.

Even as ASI has allowed the project to slip out of its grasp, the Swiss-based New Open World Corporation’s new seven-wonders-of-the-world campaign, which galvanised 1.5 crore people into voting (either through online polling or SMS) for the Taj Mahal, has shown the possibilities of community involvement, says conservationist Amita Baig. Though UNESCO distanced itself from the polling, calling it unscientific and undemocratic, the voting—the marketing rights for which were bought by The Bhaskar Group’s I Media Corporation—managed to create an extraordinary level of excitement despite, says its executive director Bharat Kapadia, no help from ASI, even when they asked for an Internet kiosk to be provided at the Taj Mahal to facilitate voting.

The challenge now is to convert the global goodwill for the Taj into better conservation practices involving the community at large, doing away with the ossified practice of letting the government run the heritage programme and allowing the people to take ownership. As of now, TMCC’s plan of providing touch-screen computers, pre-recorded tours, toilets (which were to be installed in the spaces originally designed for them in the servants’ quarters), drinking water facilities and rest areas in the centres, remains in a limbo. As do plans in consultation with the Agra Development Authority of redesigning the parking areas and improving access to the monument. As Soni says, private participation is not just a question of money. It is also a question of caring. The people of India voted to show their concern, now ASI has to capitalise on it. ■

FLOORED PLAN

The project hoped to enhance the visitors’ experience of the Taj Mahal



1.5 crore voted for Taj as one of the seven wonders of the world

Rs 14 crore offered by Tatas for restoration